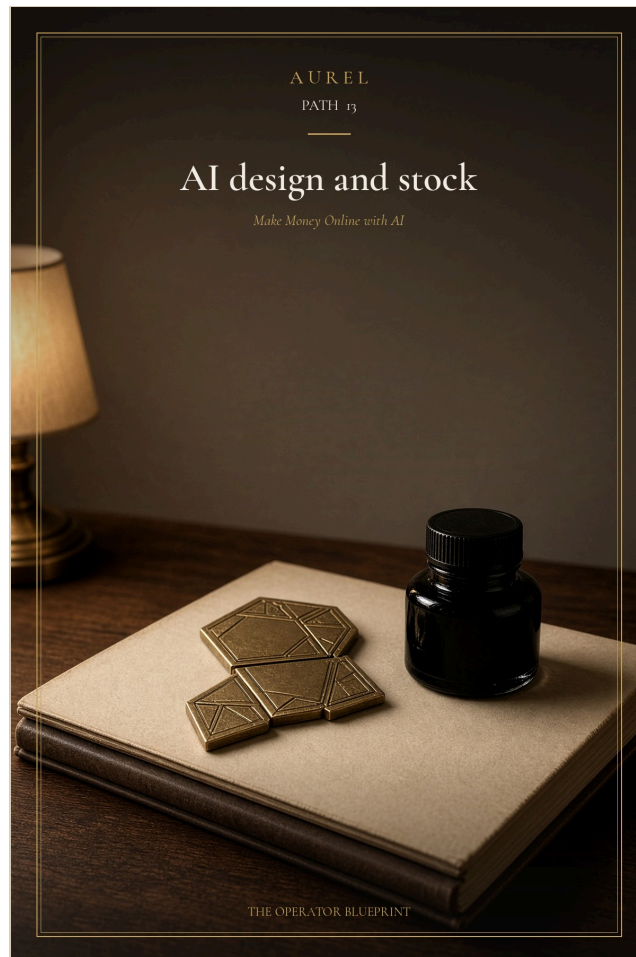




PATH 13

AI design and stock

A library, not a lottery ticket. One style, many variations.

36 minute read · 7,832 words

Who this is for

You can produce a coherent set of icons, patterns, or simple graphics.

Time to first

30–90 days to meaningful payout

Tools

First sale

A first payout, however small, that proves the account works.

Cash window

Slow then compounding

Leave this alone

Your design tool, one marketplace, a license you actually read, a 90-minute weekly block.

One upload and waiting. Unlicensed copies. Raw unedited dumps if the marketplace forbids them.

What this actually is

The definition

A stock library is a catalog you add to on a schedule. Not a lottery ticket. Not a shop you open once. One style. Many variations. Buyers search for a job — line icons for a budgeting app, a seamless pattern for packaging, a simple pack for a slide deck — and they pick the set that already looks like it belongs together.

You are selling files a stranger can drop into a project this afternoon. Consistent line weight. A palette that does not fight itself. Names that match how people search. A cinematic hero image that took six hours will sit unsold. Sets that look like a product get downloaded.

AI is a draft engine, not a dump chute. Some marketplaces restrict raw model output. Even when they allow it, buyers can smell unedited generations: warped type, patterns that do not tile, icons on three different grids. Clean, vectorize, or redraw until the file is yours and the set looks like one person made it on purpose.

The money is slow, then compounding. Month one is an account and a handful of sets. Month three is a small payout that proves the pipes work. Month six is a library that earns on a Tuesday you did not open the laptop. If you need rent this month, this is the wrong path. If you can give it ninety minutes a week for a season, it starts to behave like a quiet second till.

What this is not

This is not a brand identity studio. You are not designing a logo system for a named company. You are stocking a drawer a stranger will open when they type a job.

This is not a printable shop. Printables solve a Tuesday problem on paper. Stock solves a file problem inside someone else's project. Different buyer, different file, different license.

This is not a generation showcase. A thread of 80 pretty images is a hobby account. A 20-file outline set on a 24px grid is a product. If you only enjoy the novelty of the prompt, you will go cold when the work is cleaning nodes.

Why this works now

Search still works. A junior designer still types budget app icon at 11pm. A baker still needs a tile that does not seam. The flood is real and it is mostly dumps: mixed styles, broken hands, unlicensed marks, titles like My Art 3. Coherence is scarce. Scarce is what gets picked.

The model can list subjects and sketch a wallet. It cannot hold a 2px stroke on a 24px grid across 40 files unless you make it. That hold is the job. The tools got faster at the draft. The buyer still pays for the set that behaves in Figma.

Marketplaces still pay. Slowly. Per download or per listing. You do not need a following if the keywords match the job. You need a family of files and a weekly block that does not vanish after week two.

Three anti-patterns

Anti-pattern one: one upload and waiting. You refresh the dashboard. You call it a business. The catalog cannot compound on a single listing. The weekly block is the product until the library catches up.

Anti-pattern two: unlicensed copies. Bank marks, teams, cartoon characters, celebrity likeness, photoreal people you cannot release. This is how accounts get banned. Banned is not a setback. It is the end of the shelf.

Anti-pattern three: a new style every Saturday. You feel creative. The catalog feels random. Buyers who grabbed finance will not come back for neon 3D coins. Pick three rules and get bored on purpose.

The deal you keep

You keep the style. You keep the weekly block. You keep the license you actually read. You do not keep a fantasy of a viral pack replacing a business, a five-marketplace empire in month one, or

files you cannot point to as yours. If those stay clean, the library can earn on a Tuesday. If any one of them breaks, you have a folder of pretty liability.

Who this is for — and who should skip it

This fits you if

This path fits if you can hold a visual language for more than one evening: 2px stroke on a 24px grid, floral patterns that share one leaf, three colors and rounded corners. You do not need a degree. You need a finish standard — cousins, not strangers from different apps.

It also fits if you are patient with search. Nobody is waiting for your drop. Buyers type a job months from now and your set is sitting there. That is the bet.

It fits if you already open a design tool without a pep talk. Figma, Illustrator, Inkscape, Affinity. If you only generate, you can still fit, but only if you will add a vector tool this week and redraw. Generating 80 images is not the skill. Making 12 files that look related is.

Skip this if

Skip it if you need cash in fourteen days. This path's first sale is a payout in 30–90 days, and that payout might be \$12. Take a service path if rent is the problem. Feed this catalog on Saturday mornings.

Skip it if your plan is one upload and a refresh of the dashboard, or if you will not read a contributor license.

Skip it if you only enjoy generating novelty and go cold when the work is cleaning nodes, checking a tile seam, or writing the same keyword list again.

Skip it if you will not kill a set. Sentiment is how dead themes sit for a year.

The honest middle

If you already sell printables, this is a cousin. Printables solve a Tuesday problem on paper. Stock solves a file problem inside someone else's project. You are stocking their drawer, not

teaching them. You can run both. Do not mash them into one listing.

If you have drawn the same wallet icon three times for freelance, you already have a set. The path is packaging, not talent. If you have never exported an SVG, you will learn that this week or you will skip this path.

Skills and time

Skills: hold three style rules, clean a vector, tile-test a pattern, write a search-shaped title, read a license, sit a 90-minute block when last week is still in review.

Time: 90 minutes a week, same day, named on the calendar. First 72 hours is heavier: account, license, first 8–12 files. After that, the block is the business. Daily dashboard checking is not work. It is a hobby that eats the next tray.

A season is 12 weeks of blocks. Miss three in a row and the library starts to rot. Plan the season before you pick a second marketplace.

Two-minute self-test

Answer yes or no. No essays.

Can I write three style rules and obey them on 12 files?

Will I read a contributor license end to end this week, including the AI section?

Can I wait 30–90 days without calling the path dead?

Will I sit a 90-minute weekly block even when nothing has sold?

Will I unpublish a set I liked if it does not move after 60–90 days?

Four or five yeses: pick the marketplace this morning. Three: this can be a Saturday cousin to a cash path, not your only till. Two or fewer: skip it this quarter. You will hate the wait and skip the block.

The offer, named in one sentence

Fill this before you open a canvas

Write this before you open a canvas: [number] [style] [asset type] for [the job], commercial use, consistent grid. If you cannot fill those brackets, you have a mood board, not a set.

Number is 8–12 to start, 20–40 when it is a working set, 80–120 only when it is truly one system. Style is the three rules. Asset type is icons or patterns or simple illustrations, not a mix. The job is who drops this into what. Commercial use is the license you actually offer. Consistent grid is the promise that two files side by side look like one author.

Five sentences that work

24 outline icons for personal-finance apps, 24px grid, 2px stroke, SVG + PNG, commercial use.

12 seamless bakery patterns for packaging, 12-inch tile, 300 dpi, commercial use.

16 simple food illustrations for meal-prep decks, three-color palette, transparent PNG, commercial use.

20 outline icons for small-clinic software, 24px grid, 2px stroke, SVG + PNG, same family as the finance set.

8 seamless botanical tiles for soap labels, 12-inch, 300 dpi, three-color palette, commercial use.

Cute stickers pack vol. 4 is a mood. Line icons for a habit tracker UI is a search. People type the job.

What they get

A folder that drops into Figma, Canva, or Illustrator and behaves. SVG plus PNG for icons. Source tile plus JPEG or PNG for patterns. A license line that matches the marketplace. Previews that are not the working files. File names a stranger can sort. One style across the set.

On Adobe Stock they get a download at the library's price. On Creative Market, Etsy, Gumroad, or your own site they get the zip you promised at the number you set.

What they do not get

Not a brand identity. Not a custom mascot. Not a course. Not custom colors on request inside a \$12 listing. Not app files. Not a font. Not an exclusive unless you signed one. Not photoreal people. Not a trademarked mark.

One style across the catalog is the advantage: pack two in the same stroke is an easy second download. Scattershot styles read as noise.

Packaging

Title: job, style, count, format. Description: the fill-in-the-blank sentence, what is in the zip, what is not, a pointer to a sibling pack. Keywords: 20–40 nouns a buyer would type. Zip matches the listing. Mockup optional: one app screen or one jam jar, not a cinematic shop film.

Do not glue three unrelated dumps into a mega pack. A mega pack is one system, 80–120 files, same three rules. If you cannot say the system in one breath, it is not a mega pack. It is a flea market.

What done looks like

The definition

Done for the first 72 hours is not a payout. It is one marketplace account submitted, one coherent set of 8–12 files live or in review, search-shaped titles, and a 90-minute weekly block on the calendar with a name.

Done for the season is a first payout, however small. Twelve dollars proves the account and the pipeline. It does not prove a business. The habit does.

Fairness test

Hold two files at arm's length. If a stranger would not guess they belong together, the set is not done. Would a junior designer expense \$12 of this without a meeting? If the honest answer is they would mix three other packs instead, keep cleaning. Coherence is the bar. Clean vectors are the floor.

Would you drop this into a real project this afternoon and not fight the grid? If no, it is not done.

Technical done

Every file shares line weight, corner radius, and palette. Two files side by side should look like one author.

Names are boring: icon-budget-wallet.svg, not FinalFINAL2.

SVG plus a PNG preview at the size they ask for, usually 1000px or 2000px.

Patterns tile. A 4-up test with no seam, dark background and light.

Nothing trademarked, no photoreal people you cannot license, no characters you do not own.

Title has job, style, count, format. 20–40 keywords. Zip matches the listing.

License and AI rules checked. Disclosure filled if they ask.

Weekly block named on the calendar.

Review queues are not your pause button. The weekly block still happens.

Not-done-yet list

Account not submitted.

License unread.

80 generated images, 0 cleaned vectors.

Three styles in one folder.

Pattern that seams at 2x2.

Title: Cute pack vol. 4.

Keywords stuffed with aesthetic and viral.

Trademarked bank mark in the wallet icon.

No weekly block on the calendar.

Four marketplaces, zero live sets.

Checking payouts daily, producing weekly never.

A mega pack that is three unrelated dumps zipped together.

Pricing and the cash window

The range

On Adobe Stock and similar libraries you do not set the price. You earn a royalty per download. Volume, metadata, and a style that keeps getting picked are the job. On Creative Market, Etsy, Gumroad, and your own site, you set the number.

If you set the price:

Small set, 8–12 icons or 4 patterns: \$8–\$14.

Working set, 20–40 icons or 8–12 patterns: \$19–\$29.

Mega pack that is truly one system, 80–120 files: \$39–\$49. Do not glue three unrelated dumps together.

A \$9 set a junior designer can expense without a meeting beats a \$79 studio system with no proof. Bundles of three related packs at \$29–\$39 outsell a lonely \$12 file if they belong together.

Quinn's first listing was \$12 for 10 files, then 20 files still at \$12, then a 40-icon finance mega pack at \$29. That ladder is the default.

When to raise

Raise a listing when you add real files, not when you get bored. 10 files at \$12 can become 20 at \$12 or 40 at \$29. New sibling jobs stay at \$12 until they prove. Do not jump a dead set from \$12 to \$29 to make it feel premium. Dead at \$12 is dead at \$29.

After a payout and a returning buyer, a bundle of three siblings at \$29–\$39 is the raise that usually works. Exclusive higher royalty is a later trade, not a day-one move.

Refunds in one sentence

If the zip does not match the listing — missing format, broken tile, files that do not open — refund and fix or unpublish. Taste is not a refund. A buyer who wanted custom colors is a custom job, not a chargeback.

Never charge for these

Never charge for a custom recolor inside a \$12 listing. Never charge for a font you do not license. Never charge as if this were a brand identity. Never charge \$79 for 8 files with no proof. Never charge nothing and call it a loss leader to a library that does not have a second product yet.

Never expect month-one rent from this path. That expectation is how you quit in week two.

Worked dollars

Do not expect month-one rent. 30–90 days to a meaningful payout. Meaningful at first is \$20–\$80. Weekly uploads and a kill window on dead sets: month four through six can look like \$150–\$400 in a decent month. That is not a promise. That is what a coherent library tends to do when the keywords match jobs.

Quinn: week 6, \$14. Month 4, \$190. Eight coherent listings, one style. A beautiful set named My Art 3 earns zero at every price.

A \$12 set downloaded twice is \$24 and a proof. A \$0 dashboard with forty unpublished experiments is a hobby folder. Count payout events, not feelings.

The first 72 hours

The 72 hours is the account and the first set. Not a shop with forty listings.

Day 1 morning

Pick one marketplace. Creative Market or Etsy if you want to set the price. Adobe Stock if you want search you do not have to find. Read the contributor license and the generative-AI rules end to end. Note whether raw output is forbidden, must be labeled, or must be redrawn. If you will not read the license, stop. You are about to upload a liability.

Write the fill-in-the-blank offer. Pick one job you can picture: a founder making a budget app, a baker mocking up a jam label. Write three style rules: stroke, grid, palette. Put them on a sticky. Quinn's: outline icons, 24px grid, 2px stroke, no fills except a 4px dot for on states.

Day 1 afternoon

Make 8–12 files, not 80. If you use a model, generate extra, then redraw or vectorize the keepers. The model can list subjects (wallet, piggy bank, receipt, chart). You draw them on the grid. Export SVG plus PNG. Tile-test any pattern at 2x2 and 4x4, dark and light.

If you cannot finish 8 files in an afternoon, the style is too complex or you are decorating. Cut the decoration. Ship 8 clean.

Day 1 night

Name the files like a stranger would sort them. icon-budget-wallet.svg, not FinalFINAL2. Write the title: job, style, count, format. Draft 20 keywords. Do not upload yet if you are tired. Tired uploads miss fields.

Day 2

Submit the account if you have not. Fill every profile field they ask for. Upload the set. Fill every listing field. Do not skip keywords. Do not skip the AI disclosure if they have one. Do not refresh the review page.

Put a 90-minute weekly block on the same day next week. Name it upload block. Same hour. Same day. If you cannot name it, you will skip it.

Day 3

Start the sibling set in the same stroke. Ten more finance icons, or e-commerce in the same grid. Do not start a new aesthetic. Do not open a second marketplace. Do not build a landing page. Do not record a YouTube about your shop.

Then close the laptop. Review queues are not your pause button and they are not your hobby. The next work is Saturday's block, not Friday's refresh.

By hour 72 you have: one marketplace, license read, 8–12 files, three written rules, a search-shaped title, a weekly block on the calendar, a sibling started. You do not have a brand. You do not have forty listings. You have a shelf.

The path, step by step

The twelve-plus moves

One style. Ten variations. Write the three rules before you draw: line weight, grid, palette. Ten files that obey them beat thirty that wander. Put the rules on a sticky you can see from the chair. If a file breaks a rule, it is not in the set. It is a different Saturday.

Name the job of the asset. Who is dropping this into what? A founder making a budget app. A baker mocking up a jam label. The job decides the content. Do not start with things I like to generate. If you cannot name the person and the project, you are making a mood board. Mood boards do not search.

Pick one marketplace and read the license. One. Four sites in month one means four profiles and zero compounding. Read AI clauses, exclusivity, and how they want files labeled. Save the PDF. Highlight the AI section. If raw output is forbidden, your process is redraw, not dump.

Make the file yours. Clean, vectorize, or redraw. No trademarks, no celebrity faces, no photoreal people you cannot license. Disclose AI when they ask. Auto-trace is a start, not a finish. Nodes get cleaned. Strokes get unified. The grid gets obeyed.

File hygiene. Same artboard. Same export. Names a stranger can sort. SVG plus PNG for icons; source tile plus JPEG or PNG for patterns. Zip it the way the listing promises. If you promised 20 SVG + PNG, the zip has 40 files, not 19 and a note.

Keywords that match the job. 20–40 terms a buyer would type. Budget app icon, not aesthetic. Front-load the title with the job and the style. Steal nouns from what already ranks, not from poetry. Keep a keyword sheet: listing, title, keywords, date uploaded, date of last review.

Upload a small coherent set. Eight to twelve files. Live is better than complete. Do not wait for a real shop. Do not wait for a custom domain. The aisle is the marketplace. Your site is a later home.

Weekly upload block. Ninety minutes, same day. Finish or start one set, export, title, upload. Sit the block even if last week is still in review. Name it on the calendar so it is not a vibe. Miss

it once, sit it the next week. Miss it three times and you already quit.

Read what already sells, then fill a gap. Sort by best-selling. Notice jobs that are thin in your style. Fill the gap. Do not trace the winner. Do not copy their files. Copy the job: they sell clinic icons and you have none; you draw clinic icons in your stroke.

Kill sets that do not move after a fair window. 60–90 days with views and no downloads is a signal. Unpublish. Double the theme that moved. If it had no views, rewrite title and thumb once before you kill it. Do not kill on day 9. Do not keep a dead theme for a year because you liked making it.

Build a family, not a flea market. Pack 2 and pack 3 are siblings of pack 1. Buyers come back for the matching stroke. Quinn's finance buyer came back for the clinic pack because the stroke matched. That return is the compound. A new aesthetic every week resets the compound to zero.

Review monthly, not hourly. One date a month: payout, top three, bottom three, next three jobs. Daily checking eats the upload block. Write the monthly number in a note. Then close the dashboard.

Seasonal variants of a set that already sells. Tax-season finance in January. Back-to-school in July. Wedding in spring. Same stroke. New job. Do not invent a new style for the season. Dress the family.

Second marketplace only after a payout on the first. Not before. Five empty shops is five places to refresh. Exclusivity is a later trade: sometimes a higher royalty for not selling the same files elsewhere. Do not sign that away on day one.

A worked example: Quinn's weekly icon set

Who

Quinn is not a studio. Quinn has Figma, a Saturday morning, and three rules on a sticky: outline icons, 24px grid, 2px stroke, no fills except a 4px dot for on states. No following. No shop film. A day job that pays rent. This path is the Saturday.

Calendar

Week 1 Saturday: Quinn picks Creative Market, reads the contributor terms including the generative-AI section, and does not dump raw output. A model helps list subjects (wallet, piggy bank, receipt, chart). Quinn draws ten icons on the grid. Title: 24px outline icons for personal finance apps — 10 files, SVG + PNG. Price: \$12. Keywords from what already ranks: budget app, fintech, wallet icon, expense tracker UI. Account submitted. Upload block named for every Saturday 9:00.

Nothing sells in week 1. Quinn does not refresh earnings. The review queue takes six days. Quinn does not open a second marketplace while waiting.

Saturday week 2: ten more finance icons, listing updated to 20 files, still \$12. Same sticky. Same export preset.

Week 3: a sibling set, e-commerce, same stroke, new listing, \$12. Cart, tag, box, star. Still not a 3D experiment.

Week 4: first monthly review. Account live. Views on finance: a handful. Downloads: zero. Quinn does not panic. Produces into the local folder for week 5.

The shipped artifact

The live listing zip: 20 SVG, 20 PNG at 1000px, names like icon-budget-wallet.svg, a one-line license note matching the marketplace, a preview sheet of the 20 on a 24px grid. Not a cinematic mockup. A grid that proves the stroke.

Later artifact: a 40-icon finance mega pack at \$29, same family, built from the two finance trays plus twenty more.

The mistake

Week 5, Quinn got bored and spent the block on a cute 3D coins experiment. Different style. Different grid. Uploaded it because the renders looked expensive. Also almost used a bank mark on the wallet because it looked professional. Caught the mark. Shipped the coins.

Recovery and the first stranger sale

Week 6: a \$14 payout. Two finance downloads, one e-commerce. Not rent. Proof the account and the files work. First stranger sale: someone Quinn has never emailed, never DMed, never met. A \$12 set. The pipe works.

Week 8, one dashboard look: finance 140 views / 4 downloads; e-commerce 90 / 2; cute 3D coins 200 views / 0. Quinn unpublishes the coins. The next four Saturdays double the outline family: wellness, calendar, small-clinic, and the 40-icon finance mega pack at \$29.

Month 4: eight coherent listings, one style. A buyer who grabbed finance comes back for the clinic pack because the stroke matches. Monthly payout \$190. Quinn still does not check the dashboard on weekdays.

What Quinn refused: trademarked bank logos, photoreal hands, four marketplaces at once, and skipping Saturday because nothing is selling yet. The habit was the product until the library caught up. The coins taught the kill window. The sticky taught the family. The \$14 taught that the pipe is real and that rent still comes from the day job.

Copy you can paste

Listing title (page hero)

24px outline icons for personal finance apps — 20 SVG + PNG files, 2px stroke

12 seamless bakery patterns for packaging — 12-inch tile, 300 dpi, commercial use

Listing description

[Asset] for [job]. [N] files in one style: [stroke / grid / palette]. Formats: [SVG, PNG]. Commercial use for [what you allow]. Not included: custom colors, app files, or a font. Pair with [sibling pack] if you need the same stroke for [related job].

Checkout line

\$12 — 20 outline icons, 24px grid, 2px stroke, SVG + PNG, commercial use as stated. No custom recolors in this listing.

Post when a set goes live

I needed a wallet icon that did not look like a different app from the chart icon. So I drew a 20-file outline set on a 24px grid and put it on [marketplace]. \$12. Same stroke on every file.

DM if someone asks where you get icons

I got tired of mixing three packs in one screen. I make outline sets on one grid and upload weekly. Finance is live, clinic is next. Link: [url]. \$12. No custom inside that price.

Email 1 — to a designer who already knows you

I put a 20-file outline set for budget apps on [marketplace]. 24px, 2px stroke, SVG + PNG, \$12. If you have been mixing packs in one UI, this is the same stroke on every file. If it is not useful, ignore this.

Email 2 — sibling set

Same stroke as the finance icons: 20 outline icons for small-clinic software, \$12. If you grabbed finance, this will drop in next to it. [url]

Email 3 — after a payout, to nobody; this is your monthly note to self, also usable as a quiet post

Month [n]: [X] sets live, one style, payout \$[n]. Still Saturday 90 minutes. Still not a studio. Next three jobs: [a], [b], [c].

Refund line

If the zip does not match the listing — missing format, files that do not open, a pattern that does not tile — email me and I will refund and fix or unpublish. Wanting a different style or a custom recolor is not a refund. That is a separate job.

Keyword seed (finance)

budget app icon, fintech UI, outline wallet, expense tracker, savings goal, invoice icon, 24px line icon, bank card outline, SVG icons, transparent PNG

Week-by-week

Week 1 — daily

Monday: pick the marketplace. Read the license, including AI. Write the offer sentence. Write three style rules.

Tuesday: 8–12 files. Redraw. Export. Tile-test if patterns.

Wednesday: titles, keywords, names. Account submitted. Do not build a landing page.

Thursday: upload. Fill every field. Weekly block on the calendar, named, same day forever.

Friday: start the sibling in a local folder. Close the payout page if you opened it.

Saturday: this is the block day if you picked Saturday. If the first set is already up, sit the block anyway. If not, finish the upload.

Sunday: off. Do not redesign the three rules.

Week 2 — daily

Monday–Friday: day job, or the cash path that pays rent. Do not open five marketplaces. Do not check review.

Saturday (or your named day): second tray, same style, same job or a sibling. Upload or update the listing. Still do not check payouts more than once.

Sunday: keyword sheet updated. Date uploaded written. Close it.

If week 1 is still in review, produce into a local folder so week 3 is an upload, not a panic.

Week 3

Third set. The three style rules should feel boring. Boring is the point. One-line catalog promise: Outline icons, 24px, 2px stroke. Write that on the sticky if it is not already there.

Still no landing page. Still no second marketplace. Still no 3D experiment unless that is the three rules, which it is not if you started outline.

Week 4

First monthly review. If the account is still in review, do not panic-open a second marketplace. Produce into a local folder so week 5 is an upload. Count sets live (or ready). Count hours in the block. If you skipped two blocks, the path is already slipping. Sit week 5 even if you are embarrassed.

Weeks 5–8. One block every week. At week 8, look at views and downloads. Unpublish the all-views-no-takes set. Double the one that moved: more files, a \$29 mega pack, or a matching pattern in the same palette.

Weeks 9–12. Stay in the family. Three more sibling jobs. If a payout landed, put the number in a note, not a passive income thread. Every week after: same day, same 90 minutes. Seasonal variants of a set that already sells (tax-season finance in January). Do not skip the block three weeks in a row. Libraries rot in silence.

Quality bar

Hold two files at arm's length. If a stranger would not guess they belong together, the set is not done. Coherence is the bar. Clean vectors are the floor.

Below the bar

Warped type. Broken hands. Patterns that seam. Five styles in one folder. A 24px set with a 22px rebel. Stray nodes from a bad auto-trace. Wallet that is a blob at 16px. Zip missing the PNG you promised. Title: My Art 3. A bank mark. A photoreal face you cannot license. Raw dumps labeled as a pack. A mega pack that is three unrelated folders.

If they can tell you generated 80 and zipped 12 without looking, you are below the bar even if the marketplace allowed the upload.

Above the bar

Clean nodes. Strokes consistent. One grid. Patterns tile at 2x2 and 4x4, dark and light. Contrast works at 16px. Exports match the listing. Names searchable. Sibling packs share the three rules. Keywords are jobs. AI labeled when they ask. You can point to why you may sell this.

A table mockup is nice. A cinematic shop film is not required. Time belongs in the files.

Five tests before you upload

Arm's-length test. Two files. One author or not.

16px test. Open the PNG at the size a UI will actually use. If it blobs, simplify.

Tile test. 2x2 and 4x4, dark and light, for any pattern. No seam, no orphan motif on the edge.

Zip test. Unzip on a second computer or a second folder. Count matches the listing. Names sort.

Rights test. No logos, no team marks, no inspired-by characters, no photoreal faces without a release. AI disclosure honest.

Fail any one and you are not done. Keep cleaning. Do not upload a fail and hope the review queue is the filter. You are the filter.

What to measure

Measure a library, not a feeling.

Week 1

Account submitted. Binary.

License read, AI section highlighted. Binary.

Sets live or in review. Target: 1.

Files in the first set. Target: 8–12, one style.

Weekly block named on the calendar. Binary.

Second marketplace opened. Target: 0.

Day 30

Sets live. If this is not rising most weeks, you have a hobby folder.

Blocks sat. Target: 4.

Views per set. Title and thumb are findable.

Downloads. May still be zero. That is allowed inside 30–90.

Family share. How many of your last sets share the three style rules. Target: all of them.

Day 90

First payout date, even if \$8.

Downloads per set after a fair window.

Conversion: downloads / views. 4% where 1% is common: double that theme. 0.1% with lots of views: kill it.

Earnings per 90-minute block. \$40 after four blocks vs \$0 — the math is done talking.

Monthly payout total. Not daily.

Family share of last six sets. Under 4, you are drifting into a flea market.

Sets killed. If this is zero and you have dead themes, you are collecting, not running a library.

Fair window: 60–90 days before you kill a set that had a real chance. Do not kill on day 9. Do not keep a dead theme for a year because you liked making it.

Ignore

Daily earnings. Follower count. Likes on a process video. Number of marketplaces. Aesthetic novelty. Other people's generation showcases. A cinematic shop film you have not made.

Passive income as a label.

One-line spreadsheet

Date uploaded, listing title, marketplace, price or royalty, files in set, views, downloads, conversion, last review date, keep or kill at day 90, family (yes/no). One row per listing. Monthly tab: payout. If you cannot fill views and downloads without opening the dashboard daily, you are using the sheet as a slot machine. Fill it on the monthly date.

Objections you will hear — including from yourself

The replies

The market is flooded with AI art. Flooded with dumps. Not flooded with coherent 24px outline sets for clinic software. You compete with files that match one job and one grid.

Stock does not pay. Single uploads do not. Libraries pay slowly. Need \$3,000 this month? Take a service path. Feed a catalog weekly and it is a second till.

They will reject AI work. Some will. Read the license in hour one and redraw. Label when they ask. Do not argue with a terms page.

I am not a designer. Then this path is only yours if you will learn a grid and a finish standard. Generating 80 images is not the skill. Making 12 files that look related is.

I should be on five marketplaces. After a payout on one. Not before. Five empty shops is five places to refresh.

Someone will steal the files. Watermark previews. Sell a clean zip a serious buyer wants. Theft is not why most accounts earn zero. Silence is.

Nothing sold in two weeks, so it is dead. Two weeks is not the window. 30–90 days after live. Review queues can eat two weeks by themselves. Sit the block.

I need a cinematic shop and a brand before I upload. Time belongs in the files. One grid mockup is enough. A shop film is a delay costume.

I should wait until I have 40 listings. Eight to twelve files live beat forty in a local folder. Live is how you learn what search does. The folder does not learn.

My friends say stock is dead. Your friends are not the junior designer typing budget app icon at 11pm. The search bar is the customer. Not the group chat.

What feeds this path

Upstream

This path eats jobs, not mood boards.

You need a design tool you will open, a license you will read, and 90 minutes a week you will not skip. You do not need a following. You do not need a playbook sold. You do not need a local Friday, though a local Friday can feed subjects (the cleaner's van icon, the gym's freeze icon).

If you cannot export SVG this week, that is the upstream skill. Learn it on file one.

Inside the marketplace

Best-sellers in your category. Search suggest. Gaps: demand with few coherent sets in a simple style. Seasonal calendar: tax, back-to-school, holidays, wedding.

Outside

App Store screenshots in a niche you know. Slide decks people present. Packaging on a shelf. The question is always: what file is missing from this person's project?

From your week. If you drew the same wallet icon three times for freelance, that is a set. If a client asked for simple food icons that are not clip art, that is a listing title.

Downstream

A family of packs. A \$29 mega pack. A bundle. A second marketplace after a payout. Your own site as a second home after strangers already buy. Printables that use the same palette, sold as a

different product, not stuffed into the stock zip. A playbook later: how to keep a 24px outline family, sold to people who want the method, not the files.

What does not feed it

Other people's generation showcases. Trend accounts that change aesthetic every Friday. Cold ads to a \$12 set in month one. A Discord for your shop with no listings. Keep a note titled jobs I can draw on a Saturday. Twelve jobs is a quarter of a catalog. Two moods and no jobs is a Pinterest account.

Mistakes

Ten-plus, and the recovery this week

One upload and waiting. The catalog cannot compound on a single listing. Recovery: sit the weekly block this week. Start the sibling. Stop refreshing payouts. The block is the business.

Unlicensed copies and trademarked logos. Bank marks, teams, cartoon characters, celebrity likeness. This is how accounts get banned. Recovery: delete the file today. If it is live, unpublish. Do not argue. Read the license again tonight.

Raw unedited dumps. Warped type, broken hands, patterns that do not tile, five styles in one folder. Buyers refund. Platforms penalize. Recovery: unpublish. Redraw 8 files that obey the three rules. Re-upload as a new coherent set.

Photoreal people you do not have rights to. Generated faces still carry risk. A simple graphic path does not need them. Recovery: cut every face this week. Replace with icons or patterns. Stay in the simple graphic lane.

Expecting a viral set to replace a business. One pack will not. A family of packs, uploaded weekly, might pay a bill. Recovery: write the 12-week block calendar today. Rent still comes from the other path until day 90 says otherwise.

New style every Saturday. You feel creative. The catalog feels random. Recovery: put the three rules back on the sticky. Next four sets obey them. The 3D experiment stays unpublished.

Keyword stuffing and poetic titles. Name the job, the style, the count, the format. Recovery: rewrite the live titles this week. 20–40 real nouns. Cut aesthetic and viral.

Checking payouts daily. A hobby that eats the next tray. Recovery: one monthly date on the calendar. Log out on weekdays. Sit the block instead.

Four marketplaces in month one. Four profiles, zero compounding. Recovery: pick the one that is furthest along. Pause the rest. Produce for that shelf.

A mega pack that is three unrelated dumps. Recovery: split them. Price the coherent one. Kill or hold the rest until they have a family.

Skipping the block because last week is in review. Review is not a pause button. Recovery: produce into a local folder this Saturday. Week 5 is then an upload, not a blank.

Keeping a dead theme for a year because you liked making it. Recovery: 60–90 day look this month. Unpublish the all-views-no-takes set. Double the one that moved.

Tools

The exact stack

One design tool you already open. Figma, Illustrator, Inkscape, or Affinity. If you only generate, add a vector tool this week. Buyers want files that scale.

One marketplace. Creative Market, Etsy, Adobe Stock, or the library whose license you read. Add a second after a payout.

The license, saved, highlighted. AI section, exclusivity, disclosure, prohibited content.

A keyword sheet. Listing, title, 20–40 keywords, date uploaded, date of last review.

Export presets. SVG and PNG at their preview size. A tile test board if you make patterns.

A calendar reminder named upload block. 90 minutes, same day.

Optional: a vectorizer you control, a small mockup of an app screen or a jam jar.

Not optional: the license, and a finish standard you can say in one breath.

Setup order

Hour one: marketplace chosen, license read. Hour two: three rules on a sticky, job named.

Afternoon: files in the design tool you already have. Day two: account, upload, calendar block.

Do not buy a new computer to ship ten outline icons.

What not to buy

A new computer. A second marketplace in week one. A shop theme. A cinematic mockup bundle of 200 scenes. A course on passive stock. A trademarked font you will embed illegally. A CRM. A Discord. Stock photo credits for photoreal people you should not be selling. Four generative subscriptions. You need one draft engine you already have and one vector tool.

The \$0 path

Inkscape or Figma's free tier. A marketplace with free contributor signup. The license PDF. A spreadsheet for keywords. A calendar app you already have. A model you already use, for subject lists, not for dumps. Library computer if you have to. That is enough to get 8 files into review this week. Paid seats and mockup packs wait behind a payout.

Checklist

Three style rules written

One job named (person plus project)

One marketplace picked

License read end to end, AI section highlighted

Raw-output rule noted (forbidden, labeled, or redraw)

8–12 files that share the job, not a vibe

Every file obeys the three rules

Vectors cleaned, no stray auto-trace nodes

Patterns tiled at 2x2 and 4x4, dark and light

Small-size (16px) test passed

No trademarks, no unlicensed people, no characters you do not own

Names searchable, not FinalFINAL2

SVG plus PNG (or the formats they ask for)

Zip matches the listing

Title has job, style, count, format

20–40 keywords that are nouns a buyer types

AI disclosure filled if they ask

Account submitted

Weekly 90-minute block named on the calendar

Sibling set started in the same stroke

Keyword sheet row created

Second marketplace not opened

Monthly review date set

Kill window understood: 60–90 days

Self-test from the who section, honestly answered

No dashboard on weekdays

Payout (when it comes) written in a note, not a thread

FAQ

How long until a payout?

Plan on 30–90 days after the first set is actually live. Review queues can eat two weeks. A first payout of \$8–\$20 is a working pipe, not a verdict on talent. Default: date the 90-day mark on the calendar the day the set goes live, not the day you had the idea.

Can I use a model?

As a sketch tool if the marketplace allows it and the file still meets their rules. Many want disclosure. Some restrict raw output. Read this week's terms. Redraw so the grid, the nodes, and the rights are yours. Default: model lists subjects, you draw on the grid.

Which marketplace first?

The one whose buyer you can picture. Designers who pay \$12–\$29: Creative Market or Etsy. Huge search, tiny per-download pay: Adobe Stock. One shelf until a payout. Default: Creative Market if you want to set the price and you can picture a junior designer. Adobe Stock if you want search and will accept royalty math.

How many files in a first set?

8–12. Enough to look like a product. You can grow a listing later or ship a mega pack when two small sets have sold. Default: 10, like Quinn, then grow the same listing to 20 before you invent a mega pack.

Do I need to be exclusive?

Not at the start. Exclusivity is a later trade: sometimes a higher royalty for not selling the same files elsewhere. Do not sign that away on day one. Default: non-exclusive until a payout exists and you can read the trade with a number in hand.

What if my account is rejected?

Fix the reason they named. Produce into a local folder so you have something to upload when you are approved. Do not open four more accounts in a panic. Default: one appeal, local folder, same marketplace.

Is this passive income?

No. Delayed income. Work is front-loaded into weekly blocks. Sales can arrive on a Tuesday you spent elsewhere. Stop feeding the library and it fades. Default: call it a library, never call it passive.

Own site or marketplace?

Marketplace is the aisle. Own site is a good second home after strangers already buy. Do not build the aisle before you have a product. Default: marketplace first, own site after a payout.

What do I do with a set that will not sell?

After 60–90 days with views and no downloads, unpublish. If it had no views, rewrite title and thumb once before you kill it. Default: one title rewrite at day 30 if views are near zero, kill at day 90 if downloads are still zero with views.

Can I mix icons, patterns, and photos?

Not at first. One asset type, one style, many jobs. Quinn's outline family is easier to grow than a shop that sells neon 3D, watercolor florals, and laptop photos. Default: icons or patterns, not both, until six live sets share the rules.

Can this replace rent?

Not in month one. Maybe a bill in month four through six if the family is coherent and the blocks happened. If you need rent this month, take a service path and keep Saturday for the library. Default: second till, not first.

What if I hate cleaning nodes?

Then this path will fail. The finish standard is the product. Default: skip this path, or spend one Saturday learning to clean 8 files until you know if you can stand it.

Should I watermark the working files?

Watermark previews. Sell a clean zip. A watermarked SVG is a broken product. Default: preview sheet with a light mark, zip clean.

How do I handle a custom request on a \$12 listing?

No inside \$12. Point to a freelance rate or a productized pack. Put the reusable subject into next Saturday's sibling if it fits the family. Default: one sentence no, one link to the listing, one note

on the jobs list.

Do I need mockups?

One simple grid or one object (app screen, jam jar) is enough. A 200-scene mockup bundle is a delay. Default: grid sheet in week 1, object mockup after a payout if you want.

What if the license changes?

Read it again the month it changes. If they ban what you have been doing, stop doing it, label or redraw as they now ask, unpublish what they now forbid. Default: calendar reminder to skim the AI section once a quarter.